Rónán Ó Laoire (Ronan O'Leary)

Senior Software Engineer | Engineering / Tech Lead | Former CTO

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PROFILE

Versatile web and mobile developer, engineering manager, tech lead and former CTO with 16 years of professional experience. Originally specialising in front-end development, my work has broadened to encompass backend engineering, custom software architecture, infrastructure and the full product lifecycle. Experienced in growing, leading and mentoring engineering teams. Most recently, I conceived, designed, developed and launched Cogar, an Irish-language social platform.

TECHNICAL EXPERTISE

Experienced full-stack and mobile engineer with a broad technical background spanning modern web and mobile applications, backend systems, APIs, cloud infrastructure and platform architecture. Skilled in designing, building, integrating and scaling production software. Extensive experience with JavaScript, TypeScript, React, React Native, Next.js, Node.js and PHP, alongside API-driven architectures, database systems, CI/CD, cloud services and third-party integrations. Comfortable adopting new technologies, using AI-assisted development workflows and taking products from concept through deployment and ongoing evolution.

ENGINEERING LEADERSHIP

Experienced engineering leader combining hands-on technical expertise with strategic and operational leadership. Previously held CTO responsibility, managing up to nine direct reports and working directly with CEOs, senior management and cross-functional stakeholders. Experienced in technical recruitment, mentoring, career development, code and team reviews, engineering standards and product roadmaps. Comfortable challenging assumptions and communicating candidly at executive level to find pragmatic solutions to technical and organisational challenges.

PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

Cogar Teicneolaíochta, Ireland | Founder & Developer

May 2025 – Present

Irish-language social platform supporting a growing global community of speakers and promoting everyday use of Gaeilge.

- Conceived, designed, developed and launched Cogar, a mobile social platform for the Irish-language community.
- Built with React Native, Expo, Supabase, Zustand and Immer, with custom external services on Hetzner.
- Own real-time operations, product growth, maintenance and wider online/offline operations.
- Develop and maintain the supporting website: cogar.ie.

Findest | Contract Senior Web Developer

November 2024 – March 2026

- Performed fractional CTO services for organisations in Amsterdam, Utrecht and Dublin, working on recruitment platforms, ATS integrations and e-commerce solutions.
- Contributed to team structures, technical architecture and planning.
- Developed infrastructure with a focus on Next.js and TypeScript applications.
- Coached engineers building bespoke applications with Next.js and React.

Busy Little Pixels, Netherlands | Founder

April 2025 – Present

- Independent software engineering consultancy designing, developing and maintaining web applications, mobile apps, websites, APIs and related systems.

Independent Contracting | Fractional CTO / Tech Lead / Senior Developer

March 2024 – November 2024

- Provided fractional CTO and senior engineering services across events, marketing technology, recruitment and e-commerce.
- Led team structuring, technical architecture and infrastructure planning.
- Built Next.js / TypeScript applications and coached developers working with modern React-based frameworks.

Picnic Technologies BV | Tech Lead, Web Team

November 2022 – March 2024

Web properties: picnic.app; jobs.picnic.app

- Led the web team and delivery of long-term roadmaps for online operations.
- Oversaw architecture, project planning, incident management and reporting.
- Mentored engineers building bespoke web applications using Next.js and React.

The Next Web BV, Amsterdam | CTO / Engineering Manager / Senior Developer

November 2017 – October 2022

Web properties: thenextweb.com and related conference, programmes and branded sites

- As CTO, reported directly to the CEO and leadership team and oversaw engineering operations, strategy and product delivery across five business verticals.
- Oversaw 13+ websites and customer properties, including internal products and mobile applications.
- Led a two-year modernisation and migration to a bespoke, headless multi-site CMS, integrating platforms and systems.
- Managed and mentored a nine-person engineering team across frontend, backend and data.
- Built technical solutions for the transition to online events during COVID-19, and supported product and editorial roadmaps.
- Maintained and optimised web properties throughout migration.

Trigger Media, Dublin | Head of Web Development

August 2016 – November 2017

Selected sites: celticdublin.com; unitopsmedia.com

- Established and led the web development team, delivering bespoke websites and WordPress / WooCommerce solutions.
- Directed implementation, SEO and digital-marketing technical solutions.
- Contributed to client pitches, tenders, acquisition and support processes; established development workflows.

Web Summit, Dublin | Senior Web Developer / Web Team Lead

February 2014 – July 2016

Web properties: websummit.com; collisionconf.com; riseconf.com

- Joined and subsequently led the web development team, reporting to the VP of Engineering and managing four developers.
- Migrated company websites from ExpressionEngine to a consolidated WordPress multisite platform.
- Developed “Flexo”, the underlying WordPress framework supporting company sites and applications.

- Led the early strategy for adopting headless / Jamstack web implementations.

EDUCATION

Dublin Business School — Higher Diploma in Web Design and Development | 2008–2010

Irish Academy of Public Relations — Higher Diploma in Public Relations | 2002–2004

REFERENCES

Patrick de Laive — Co-founder, The Next Web | +31 6 4200 4200

Lars Lockefeer — Engineering Manager, Picnic Technologies BV | lars.lockefeer@teampicnic.com